THE SHE LIST UNDER 50

THE **SPORTSWOMEN**

The Game Changer

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Currently ranked 7th in the ICC women's T20 batting rankings, Shafali Verma came in as an injury replacement in the 2025 ODI World Cup. Her exploits with the bat—and ball—were instrumental in India winning the tournament

SHAFALI VERMA, 22
Indian cricketer
Rohtak, Haryana

Behind the well-timed, lofted drives, fierce cuts and mighty hoicks that shred hapless opposition bowlers and built the reputation of Shafali Verma as a fearsome attacking batsman lies a now-familiar tale of determination. Shafali's father Sanjeev, a small-time jeweller, didn't err in detecting the uncut diamond in his ward, and got her admitted to a local academy disguised as a boy after many others rejected her for her gender. She was nine. At age 15 in 2019, Shafali got her maiden India call-up—the youngest Indian cricketer to make an international debut, a record broken only recently by Vaibhav Sooryavanshi.

At her Test debut against England two years later, she fell just four runs short of a hundred. In 2024, she notched up the second fastest Test century in women's cricket and then converted it into a double hundred. In 2023, she led India to victory in the inaugural ICC Under-19 Women's T20 World Cup in South Africa. "Becoming captain of the India U-19 team was a big turning point for me," says Shafali. "It gave me a chance to take responsibility and grow as a player."

Shafali Verma's fearless batting approach is propelled by her iron resolve to succeed—she fell back upon relentless training even when left out of the India team for the 2025 women's ODI World Cup. Then, a burst of fortune—called in as a late injury replacement, Shafali lit up the knockouts. She owned the final with a match-winning 87 and two crucial wickets to help India win. "It felt like life had given me another chance, and I had to make the most of it," she says.

Indeed, Shafali brings an X-factor to the table, served with cold, clinical force. Still just 22, she will serve Indian cricket for many more years. The inevitable ups and downs of a sporting career colour her advice for other women. "Always believe in yourself. There will be difficult times, and not everything will go your way, but don't let one setback decide your future." ■

— Rahul Rawat

HER INSPIRATION

"As a role model, I've always looked up to Sachin Tendulkar sir. I used to watch his batting videos with my father when I was young, and he inspired me to dream of playing for India. My father has been my biggest inspiration, because he has always stood by me and encouraged me to keep going"

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**